

Meeting your client?

Some top tips...

Adapted from slides by Simon Lock

Top tips for your first client meeting

- Get to know your main point of contact
- Ask them how they'd like you to contact them – and take their contact details!
- Find out what ***they think*** the business problem is
- Listen politely to what ***they think*** the solution should be
- Try to identify the limits (“outer edge”) of the solution

Top tips for your first client meeting

- Arrange a demo of any existing systems
- See if you can get a tour of their site or activities, virtually or online
- Make sure the client understands the **release schedule** (the deadlines on Blackboard/in the slides are the *latest possible* dates)
- Ask them for their dates when they will be **available to give you feedback** from MVP or Beta – you may need to move your releases earlier
- Ask for other **dates when they know they will be busy** – and tell them when your deadlines and holidays are

Initial Objectives

The aim of the meeting is to:

- Start to understand the project context
- Become familiar with the client's business
- Learn about the domain they operate in
- Identify key stakeholders
- Uncover their main concerns
- Become aware of the problems and challenges

Requirements Engineering

This is the process of establishing the **features** that the client **requires** from a system and the constraints under which such features must operate.

The requirements are the recorded **description** of the system features and the constraints that are generated during this process.

We will talk to you more about this in the coming weeks, but the task starts with your first client meeting

Dangers of **not** doing Requirements Engineering

- We must find out **what** to build **before** we build it!
- Common trap: to **think** we know what the client wants and blaze ahead building it....
- ...only to realise later we were **wrong**!
- Having wasted time, effort and money (grades)

Eliciting requirements

- How do we actually find the requirements?
- We don't just know them intuitively
(a rookie developer mistake is to think that you can!)
- We have to actually make an effort to find them
- They can be elicited using a variety of techniques...

Reading documentation!

- We'll talk about this more in Week 3
- Organisations often have a lot of documentation: process documents, regulations, manuals etc
- Ask your client for theirs!
- If we can get hold of them and pick them apart, we can understand how the organisation operates and then specify requirements to support that operation

But!

- Be aware that people don't always follow official regulations!
- Being able to identify work-arounds being used is essential!

Interviews

- An obvious way to find out about an organisation is to talk to stakeholders (workers, managers, customers)
- This may be an informal chat over coffee
- Or a formal, planned, structured interview
- Be open-minded and avoid pre-conceived notions.
- You can prompt the interviewee to get discussions going by using a 'springboard' question...
- BUT do try to listen to their answers!

Observation

- Another way to identify requirements is by observation
- Watch the 'lived' practices within an organisation
- Social and organisational factors may be observed
- Some social scientists (ethnographers) are explicitly trained in the observation and analysis of work
- But it is possible to undertake our own studies

System Analysis

- Existing systems encapsulate work practices
- If we analyse/deconstruct them, we gain insight
- Reverse engineering systems to derive requirements
- BUT.... This assumes existing systems are good
- If they are that good, why build something new?

Problems with Requirements Engineering

- Stakeholders will express their needs in their own words
 - This may be in the technical jargon of their field
 - They may struggle to articulate what they want
 - Or use concepts that only make sense to them!
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- Different stakeholders often have conflicting needs
 - How can you reconcile these?
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- Stakeholders frequently don't know what they want
 - Often they don't even know what they currently do (or at least can't explain)

Problems with Requirements Engineering

- Organisational and political factors may be present
- Development is **not** just a technical challenge, but a human one
- Requirements may change during the analysis process
- New stakeholders emerge or the environment changes
- Different people in the organisation may contradict each other

How to solve these problems

- If you're unclear about anything the client says, ask them!
- Never pretend you understand things you don't – the clients will always prefer you stop and check
- Send them emails after the meeting to confirm what you think you were told
- If you're unclear what things mean, or need help, talk to your mentor and come to the Drop-Ins on Fridays for help

Use your first meeting to start your Requirement Engineering Process

- Ask the client if they can share information about the existing systems and their organisation
- Ask if you can plan another meeting specifically for Requirement Engineering – don't assume this is something you can do in your first meeting
- Ask if you can come and observe their work – but don't be surprised/upset if they say no (they are very busy)

Top tips for your first client meeting

- Keep the agenda focused – this is your introduction, and you won't be able to do everything you want in the first meeting. You can always arrange another one!
- Never leave a meeting without arranging the next one! It's easier to do this when you are all together
- Research the organisation beforehand and come with questions
- Be enthusiastic! The clients are volunteering to work with you – make sure they know you appreciate that

Meeting your client in person

- If they are in Bristol and you can travel to meet them, save your receipts/tickets and **claim the money back!** (Ask Sarah how to do this)
- If you **plan to meet them in Bristol**, we can book rooms for you – but arrange to meet them somewhere obvious like the MVB atrium (tell them what you look like and ask them for their description)
- Do not arrange to meet the client one-on-one – you should always be meeting them as a team